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Dane County Board reinstates \$80K to sheriff's budget for new ALPR provider

Questions now: What vendor will county choose after ditching Flock, and will other municipalities follow suit?

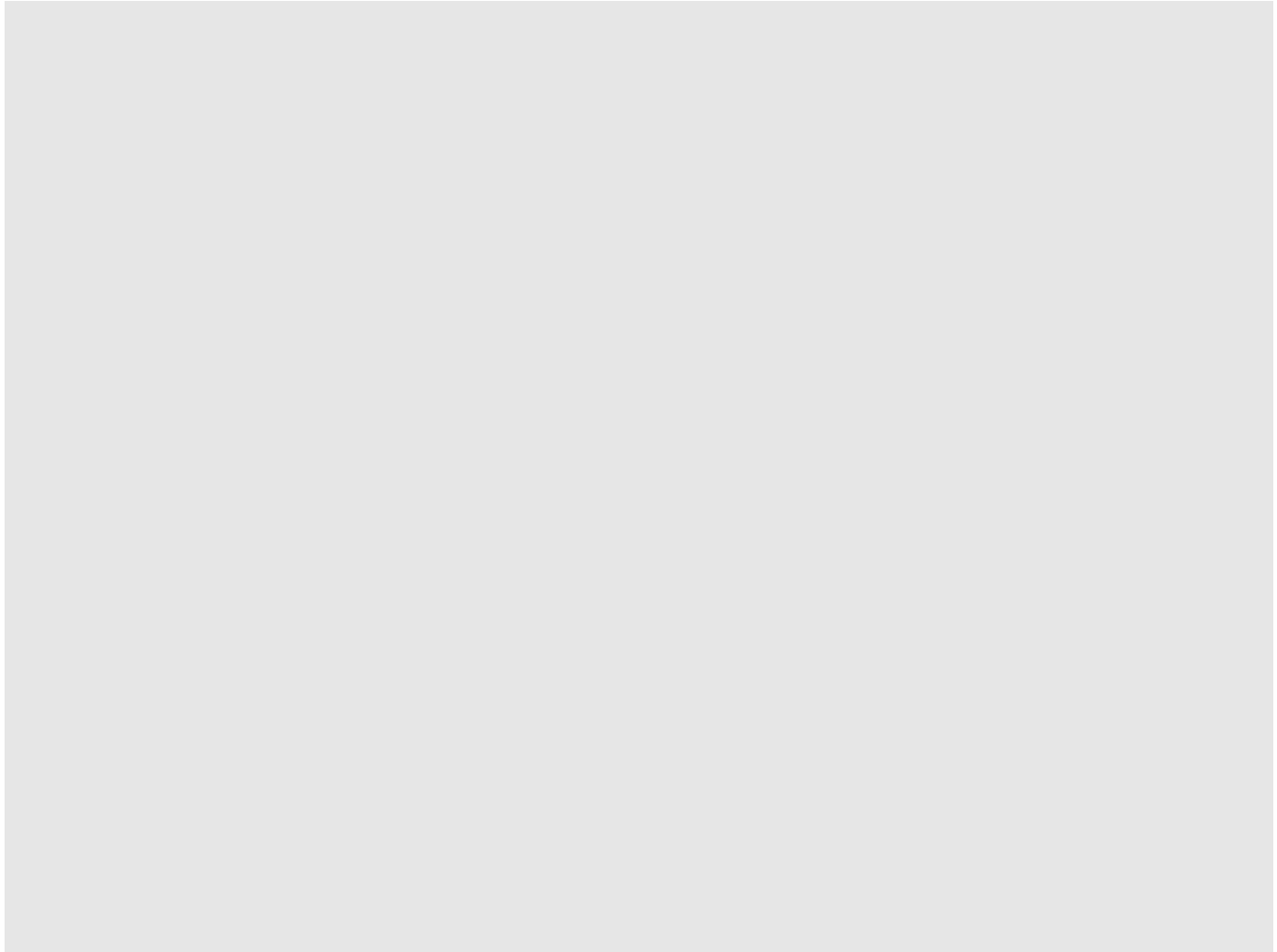
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Jun 24, 2026



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File photo: A pole-mounted Flock Safety automated license plate reader (ALPR) camera and solar panel in Sun Prairie.

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Now that the Dane County Board has voted to reinstate \$80,000 into his budget, Sheriff Calvin Barrett is eager to find a new automated license plate reader (ALPR) system to replace the Flock cameras.

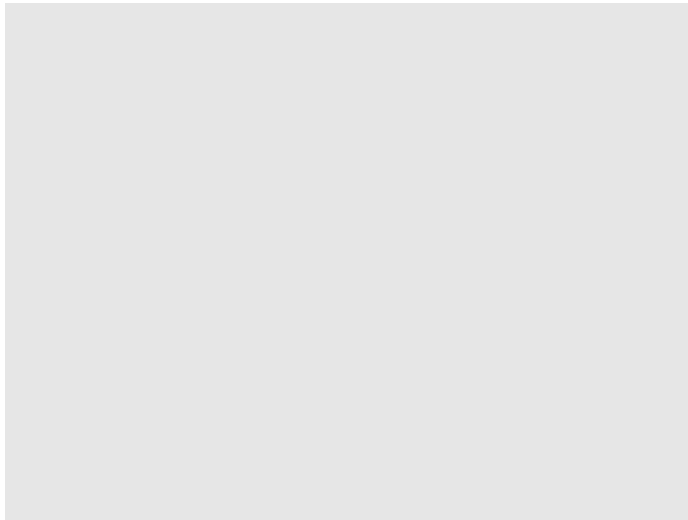
"There has been concern from the community that this is jeopardizing public safety as we move in to the busiest time of the year, summertime," Barrett said in an interview.

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"Right now, we have nothing."

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The county board voted in April to cut the \$80,000 that covered the annual Flock Safety subscription, effectively canceling the service after May 31. According to a county news release, the resolution cited concerns raised by residents, policymakers, and privacy experts about reported and verified abuses of data collected through Flock's ALPR network, including informal data-sharing with federal agencies that bypasses oversight and accountability measures.



A covered Flock Safety camera is shown on June 8 on U.S. Highway 12/18 just west of State Highway 73 near Deerfield. The Dane County Sheriff's Office said it covered up the automated license plate reader (ALPR) cameras when Flock did not remove them by May 31, the date the county's contract with Flock expired.

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At its June 4 meeting, the board voted 26-7 to reinstate that money for purchasing and implementing a new ALPR system.

"We can now move forward with request for proposals because we have the funds secured," said Barrett.

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The June 4 resolution said the board "supports the use of an ALPR system that incorporates strong privacy and security controls, including strict limitations on data access, retention, and sharing."

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“It is further the intent of the Board that all data collected through such a system remain under the full ownership and control of the Dane County Sheriff’s Office, without unauthorized third-party access and complete, transparent documentation when access is granted.”

Barrett said that 2025 saw a dramatic drop in many types of crimes in the county, and while he gives a lot of credit to hiring the right people, he also thinks the cameras had something to do with it.

"It's everything together," Barrett said. "I think we had the recipe for a crime-reducing strategy and now we've lost the main ingredient in that (ALPR cameras). ... And the data supports that."

Given the county’s large area and the limited number of sheriff’s deputies, Barrett said having ALPR cameras can play a big role in public safety in rural areas.

Widespread Flock use, then some pullback

In the past few years, many south-central Wisconsin counties, cities, and villages have installed ALPR systems, which use cameras and software to automatically capture, analyze, and store license plate numbers, and often, additional identifying information from the backs of vehicles. The information can be used to alert law enforcement to stolen or wanted vehicles, help them solve other crimes, or locate missing persons.

Atlanta-based Flock Safety calls itself the “largest public-private safety network”

and says it is used by more than 5,000 law enforcement agencies in 49 states.

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The Dane, Columbia, and Jefferson County Sheriff's offices, as well as the Cottage Grove, Marshall, Monona, Sun Prairie, and Waunakee police departments were all using Flock cameras at the start of the year, as were Jefferson, Lodi, Poynette, Watertown, and Whitewater. Lake Mills police had them installed this year.

But after concerns about data sharing and transparency, Dane County as well as the cities of Verona, Oshkosh, Monona, and Fitchburg, among others, ended or voted to let their contracts with Flock expire. And the McFarland Police Department announced in May that it would not move forward with its plan to install Flock cameras, citing the decreasing number of cameras in the area as one reason.

Privacy concerns, data sharing questions

Besides pushback against what some see as Big-Brother overtones and “surveillance creep,” there have also been concerns about whether U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) and other federal agencies can access Flock data from local communities.

Flock said in a blog post that “ICE does not have direct access to Flock cameras, systems, or data, unless the agencies that control their data expressly and deliberately allow it.”

But while each local government agency or business that has a contract with Flock can decide which other agencies it will share its data with, it is possible one of those other agencies could in turn still share that data with a federal agent.

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The ability to share ALPR data among local and regional law enforcement increases the potential of locating a vehicle in the case of a missing person, stolen auto, or other crime in which a vehicle is used, by having more camera locations to draw from.

"We will share data no matter what, for public safety, as long as the agencies that we work with share the same privacy protection standards that we have," said Barrett.

"We have probably one of the highest standards of access, probably in the state," he said of Dane County.

Sun Prairie Police Chief Kevin Warych said one of his takeaways from "The 9/11 Commission Report" was the importance of information sharing.

"I'm 100% behind the license-plate reader technology," Warych said, adding that they just have to do it the right way and "really gain the trust of the community, too."

What will other municipalities do?

While the Sun Prairie Police Department currently uses Flock cameras, Warych said he will be meeting with city council members on the issue before bringing forth a budget initiative in July.

"I have not made a decision either way," he said of keeping Flock or going with another vendor. "But I am sold on the technology."

Asked about the idea of coordinating with other nearby police departments and the sheriff's office to have the same vendor, Warych said "I can say that this is a frequent topic of our chief's meetings."

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In a recent guest column in an area newspaper, Sheriff Barrett wrote that there are approximately 16 companies that offer "advanced ALPR systems with robust privacy safeguards, reliable performance in rural environments, and proven track records in balancing public safety with individual rights."

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"Obviously we'd love to all be on the same one," Barrett said in an interview, but noted that each community has different budgets.

"Once we ... get the approval, then we can start focusing on how that will interact with other agencies."

"The community trusts us with firearms ... they trust us to do a lot," said Barrett. "Trust us with the ALPR."

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